

RETHINKING GLOBAL GOVERNANCE

FRAGMENTATION, REFORM, AND AFRICA'S RISING ROLE

Amb Anil Sooklal, High Commissioner of South Africa to India,
and Dr Samir Bhattacharya, Associate Fellow at Observer Research Foundation

As we approach the end of 2025, the world is more fractured than it has been in decades. The global governance architecture, rooted in post-World War structures, is increasingly out of sync with contemporary political, economic, and demographic realities. The very institutions created to preserve peace, facilitate cooperation, and promote development are now viewed as outdated, unrepresentative, and often ineffective.

While Samuel Huntington's "clash of civilisations" continues to echo, today's global divisions are far more layered. Instead of a simple East vs. West binary, the world today faces a complex multipolar environment, divided by divergent political systems, economic interests, technological development, and environmental vulnerabilities. As a result, global governance is not only contested in values but also in its structure, authority and legitimacy.

The crumbling foundations of global governance

The winners of World War II laid the foundations of current global governance. Institutions like the United Nations (UN), the World Bank, and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) were created to shape a stable and rules-based international order, reflecting the realities of the post-World War II era. While these organisations managed to keep the world relatively peaceful for 80-odd years, it is increasingly failing to do so. One particular reason behind its failure is its outdated structure, where a handful of powerful states decide for the entire planet.

Indeed, the UN Security Council, the central body for maintaining international peace and security, still reflects the power dynamics of 1945. The veto-wielding permanent members (P5), the US, UK, France, Russia, and China, frequently paralyse the Council when their interests clash. From the war in Palestine, Syria, Ukraine, Myanmar, Sudan and elsewhere, the UN has failed to prevent it. Instead of serving as a guardian of peace, the UN is often seen as a stage for geopolitical posturing.

The problem isn't only about inaction. It's also about representation. Paradoxically, while over half of the Security Council's agenda concerns African conflicts, no African nation holds a permanent seat. Despite widespread support for the Ezulwini Consensus, Africa's official position since 2005, calling for greater representation, the continent remains excluded from top decision-making roles. The same imbalance persists at the IMF and World Bank, where voting power remains skewed in favour of wealthy nations, even as developing countries face the brunt of debt, climate, and health crises.